

Guts & Glory

Sweat and striving make badminton player Saina Nehwal world No. 6 and India's No. 1 athlete

| By Sharda Ugra |

Fifteen minutes on the treadmill at 10.5 kph, then another 15 at 11 kph and half an hour at 12 kph. At which stage, instead of toppling off and gasping for an ambulance, a 10-minute clip at 14 kph to finish. This is Saina Nehwal's aerobic target and she has two more sessions to get there, to run 15 km in 70 minutes, burning around 1,300 calories. Perhaps you would like to try it some time. "It's a horrible workout," coach Pullela Gopichand says, caught between a grimace and grin. Nehwal throws herself at the numbers because, to her, the routine is not torture; what

may look like torture to us is actually her routine. Three weeks before the World Badminton Championships, the treadmill is her staging post to get her to where she needs to be.

Ready.

At the Hyderabad World Championships (August 10 to 16) Nehwal will be India's foremost challenger. World junior champion and Olympic quarter-finalist. The first Indian woman to win an Asian Satellite event,

the first Indian woman to win a four-star tournament, the first Indian woman and the youngest winner of a Super Series Grand Prix (one of the game's 12 elite events), the Indonesian Open in June. She is world No. 6. And she is 19.

Yet, this is no "teen prodigy" of youthful, quick-silver gifts. This is a player hewn out of more primordial material: muscle, bone, sinew and flesh. A pure athlete built through pounding

blood and unflagging will.

Understand this: Saina Nehwal is India's No. 1 athlete. It is badminton that has given India its best-performing athletes, poetic because the sport was invented here. In the last three decades, it is the pure athletic sport in which Indians have won titles the world covets. Nehwal is the younger of two girls born to badminton-playing Haryanvis, Harvir and Usha but she also traces her lineage to Prakash Padukone

and Pullela Gopichand.

Most 19-year-old shoulders would shrivel at the idea, but Nehwal does not do shrinking. She arrives at Gopichand's academy with a slanting morning sun and has stopped travelling out of town three weeks before the Worlds. "It's such a big tournament, I can't play badly here. I want to do well," she says looking across at the Gachibowli Indoor Stadium, venue of the Worlds. Driving in for training in her grey